TSA 2018

Critical Thinking

Questions taken from the TSA Oxford 2018 Section 1 question paper

Questions	Total marks	Time limit
25	25	45 minutes

Instructions

- You have **45 minutes** to answer all **25 questions**.
- Each question is worth **one mark**. There are no penalties for incorrect answers, so attempt every question.
- Each question has five options, A to E. Choose the one option you consider correct.
- Calculators are **not** permitted. You may use this paper for rough working.
- Questions are numbered 1 to 25 for this set. The number in brackets shows the question's number in the original TSA 2018 paper, e.g. **1 (Q3)**.

How the time limit was set

The time limit follows the TARA Critical Thinking module (22 questions in 40 minutes), scaled to the 25 questions in this set: 25 × 40 ÷ 22 = 45.45 minutes, rounded to the nearest minute (45 minutes).

Score: _____ / 25

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1 (Q1) Fear of death prompted us to develop technology that helps people live longer. But those same technological advances have condemned us to fear of infirmity and dementia, since so many of us will live to an advanced age. So as to eliminate this new fear, once we have reached old age we should be assisted to die if we choose death over a sad decline. According to current estimates, dementia affects almost 50 per cent of people by the age of 85, and bodily infirmity is guaranteed to develop further the older we get. There is no cure for old age.

Which one of the following best expresses the main conclusion of the above argument?

A Technology has advanced to the point where we can now choose when to die.

B Euthanasia should be readily available to people who have reached a certain age.

C The fear of infirmity and dementia is worse than the fear of death.

D We must develop technology to cure dementia and infirmity.

E We should focus on the health of the young instead of that of the old.

2 (Q3) The family had to choose between planting maize or soybeans. Maize received a better market price than soybeans last year, but maize requires a much greater fertiliser input to ensure high yields. Because they could not obtain credit to purchase additional fertiliser, they planted soybeans even though the crop is likely to earn less at harvest time.

Which one of the following most closely parallels the reasoning used in the above argument?

A In order to go on the trip to New York, the students have to raise enough money. They are failing to raise much money, so it is unlikely they will go on the trip.

B She can apply for a loan from a bank or a local credit union. The credit union has higher customer service ratings, so she hopes it will give her the loan.

C To be able to buy their first home, they had to save money for a deposit. They bought a house last year, so they must have saved enough money for a deposit.

D You only get a promotion if you meet your sales targets. You are sure to get a promotion because you met last quarter's sales targets.

E To exchange currency, the tourists could use a bank or, for a poorer exchange rate, use their hotel. They had to use the hotel as there was not enough time to find a bank.

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3 (Q4) The world is now producing more farmed fish than beef. In 2012, fish production reached a record 66 million tonnes; cattle-farm output levelled out at 63 million tonnes. This ought to be good news for the environment. Cattle farming is one of the biggest contributors to global warming, while fish farming – as well as being sustainable – produces little pollution. Fish such as the silver carp can be reared on existing rice paddies, and they feed on grass, plankton and detritus. Species such as salmon, however, are carnivorous and are fed on smaller fish like anchovies caught in the wild. As a result, salmon can only be farmed by further depleting wild fish stocks.

Which one of the following can most reliably be drawn as a conclusion from the above passage?

A Fish farmers who produce carnivorous fish should switch to producing non-carnivorous fish.

B Fish farming is likely to become increasingly more widespread in comparison to beef farming.

C Fish farming will always be better for the environment than cattle farming.

D It would be better for the environment if a greater proportion of farmed fish was non-carnivorous.

E Where possible, farmers should opt for more environmentally friendly forms of farming.

4 (Q5) There is an urgent need to improve the recruitment procedures for teaching positions at universities. There have been numerous cases in which academics have failed to hire outstanding young researchers and talented lecturers. For example, a research fellow from Germany complained that his applications for lecturing jobs were rejected despite his impressive research and publication record. Another scholar from Spain, who had received the Excellence in Teaching Award, also failed to get a job. A number of similar complaints have forced the Department of Education to introduce a policy which requires universities to staff the relevant selection committees with representatives from independent human resources consultancies. This measure will improve recruitment procedures.

Which one of the following is an underlying assumption of the above argument?

A Academics are driven by egotistic interests when they recruit faculty members.

B Human resources consultants will be able to spot suitable candidates for teaching positions.

C A good publication record can diminish your chances of being hired.

D The primary goal of universities is to maintain the quality of teaching, rather than excellence in research.

E Graduates of German and Spanish universities have fewer chances of being hired for teaching positions.

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5 (Q9) Shooting is not just positive for rural economies, but is also necessary for conservation efforts. In various peripheral rural places in Britain, sport shooting related jobs are a mainstay of local economies, often accounting for as much as a third of the labour market. However, since humans disturbed the ecosystem by eradicating the top predators, destroying habitats and introducing non-native species, we are also now responsible for reducing further damage – conserving – by continuous management. This means shooting overpopulated species to minimise the risks of disease and starvation, and dominant foreign species in order to conserve weaker native ones. Additionally, the management of the environment for the purposes of sport shooting can have very positive conservation effects; for example, many endangered birds of prey now thrive on shooting estates.

Which one of the following, if true, most weakens the above argument?

A Wild flower numbers and bee populations have increased on shooting estates.

B Many animals that are shot are sold on to butchers and enter the food market.

C People from all over the world travel to Britain to engage in sport shooting.

D Many native species such as the red squirrel are at threat from foreign species.

E Re-introducing top predators such as wolves is a more effective means of conservation.

6 (Q10) Thousands of parents have recently been prosecuted by local education authorities for taking their children out of school to go on holiday during term time. I took my daughter out of primary school for a two-week holiday every year. The headmistress made no objection and said it would give the other kids time to catch up with her! She was able to learn a foreign language and spend some rewarding time with her French pen-pal. She eventually achieved top grades at school and a degree in mathematics, so it obviously did her no harm! Parents, not governments, know best how to raise children. This law is quite unnecessary.

Which one of the following is the best statement of the flaw in the above argument?

A It is an appeal to tradition because it suggests that taking children on holiday in term time used to be acceptable.

B It is based on authority as it uses the headmistress's lack of objection in support.

C It assumes that because the daughter's good grades were achieved after her foreign holidays, they were the result of the holidays.

D It is based entirely on the one example of the daughter and generalises from that.

E It assumes that learning some French adequately compensated for the work the daughter missed.

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7 (Q11) Evidence suggests that children whose parents are married tend to fare better – financially, academically and socially – than children of unmarried parents. The government is therefore proposing a tax break for married couples, whereby married couples are reimbursed by approximately £150 per person per annum. This idea is flawed for several reasons. First, it punishes those whose partners have left them and broken up the marriage. Secondly, it punishes those who, through no fault of their own, have been unable to find a partner. Thirdly, it assumes that people in unhappy relationships will persevere in their unhappy state for something like £12.50 a month. This is patently absurd. Finally, it makes the bogus assumption that maintaining a poor marriage will be better for the children than separation.

Which one of the following best expresses the main conclusion of the above argument?

A A poor relationship could be more damaging for a child than separation.

B Children whose parents are married tend to fare better than children of unmarried parties.

C It is absurd to think that people will persevere in an unhappy relationship for the sum proposed.

D The government's proposal punishes single parents.

E The government's idea of giving married couples tax breaks is flawed.

8 (Q15) The award of a Nobel Prize in economics, but not in psychology, sociology or anthropology, seems to imply that economics is not a social science, but an exact one, like chemistry or physics. Underpinning this idea is the thought that the human world operates like the physical world. Economists themselves perpetuate this impression by dealing in hard quantitative data, as opposed to observation and qualitative analysis. The defining feature of the natural sciences is their consistent success in making predictions, but almost all economists failed to predict the 2008 financial crisis. The striking collapse of LTCM, a hedge fund set up by two economists who were later awarded the Nobel Prize, further underscores the limits of economics to make accurate forecasts.

Which one of the following can be drawn as a conclusion from the above passage?

A The Nobel Prize should not be awarded for economics.

B The human world is not part of the physical world.

C Economics is not a science like chemistry or physics.

D Economists cannot predict the behaviour of markets.

E Hard quantitative data has no role in economics.

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9 (Q16) Mobile phone use and driving under the influence of alcohol are not the only examples of irresponsible driver behaviour. Tiredness when driving a vehicle is said to be responsible for 300 deaths per year. Astonishingly, almost half of male drivers and 22% of female drivers admit to having fallen asleep at the wheel. If we assume (and it seems reasonable to do so) that even more people are injured than killed as a result of accidents caused by tiredness, it is clear that tiredness while driving is a major road safety issue – and entirely preventable. If we wish to preserve our own lives and those of others we should not drive a car knowing that we have had insufficient sleep or rest to drive safely.

Which one of the following is an underlying assumption of the above argument?

A Women are more careful than men about driving when they are tired.

B Drivers are able to recognise when they are dangerously tired.

C Falling asleep when driving is more dangerous than using a mobile phone while driving.

D People whose jobs involve long distance driving can always avoid driving while tired.

E Tiredness has been insufficiently highlighted in road safety campaigns.

10 (Q17) There has been a significant rise in the number of children with rickets. This has resulted from the airless, indoor world we have created for ourselves. Rickets is caused by a deficiency of vitamin D, which is produced in response to sunlight on the skin. Where children used to play outside they mostly stay indoors immersed in virtual realities via various electronic media. Instead of long summer evenings outdoors, we close the curtains to prevent sunlight falling on our screens. The lure of technology is compounded by adult fears of the risks to children if they are left to roam free in the outside world; in any case there are fewer accessible public spaces for open air activity. Curing this will require an awful lot more than vitamin pills.

Which one of the following, if true, most weakens the above argument?

A There has been a large growth in areas designated as national parks and in urban parkland.

B Diet has a much more significant effect on vitamin D intake than sunlight.

C The incidence of rickets is confined to a few hundred cases a year.

D In the 19th century, when the incidence of rickets was much higher, terrible air pollution and smog affected the large population of city dwellers.

E Many people can’t afford or be relied on to take vitamin D supplements.

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11 (Q21) When mobile phones first became relatively inexpensive many parents bought them for their teenage children on the grounds that having access to a phone would keep them safe. High profile cases of abduction at the time underscored the need to improve safety for young people. But today mobile phones invariably have access to the internet, which has made young people vulnerable to stalking and cyberbullying. Since the stated case for buying teenagers mobile phones was to keep them safe, we should now restrict their access to them.

Which one of the following is the best statement of the flaw in the above argument?

A The incidence of cyberbullying and stalking does not undermine the respects in which mobile phones keep teenagers safe.

B If you restrict young people's access to mobile phones they will continue to bully one another on other devices.

C Access to mobile phones has not stopped teenagers from being attacked while out alone at night.

D The majority of teenagers are not affected by the problems of stalking and cyberbullying.

E It ignores the fact that there are other ways of keeping children safe.

12 (Q22) A new supermarket scheme awards money-off vouchers to customers who spend £40 a week on their grocery shopping. As your weekly shop only costs £15, you are not eligible for vouchers.

Which one of the following most closely parallels the reasoning used in the above argument?

A A discount is given to gym members who introduce new customers. You brought two friends who joined up, so you will get a discount.

B Dessert is given to all those who have completed their main course. You have not eaten your main course so you will not be given dessert.

C Anyone between the ages of 18–30 inclusive gets admission into the nightclub half-price. You are 30 so you will not pay full price.

D A bursary is given to those on incomes below £10 000. You earn £9000 so you will receive a bursary.

E Only experienced wine drinkers can appreciate a good wine. You prefer poor quality wine as you have only recently started drinking wine.

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13 (Q23) The plethora of house-buying and relocation programmes on television these days may well stimulate an interest in lovely properties, but they are a bad thing because at the same time they make viewers who could never afford the houses shown feel both envious and worthless.

Which one of the following illustrates the principle used in the above argument?

A People who watch house-buying programmes do not tend to have nice houses themselves.

B Seeing others enjoy luxuries that they have not got can motivate people to work harder to earn enough to support the same lifestyle.

C The public thinks a celebrity lifestyle must be great, but most celebrities are constantly worried about dropping out of the public eye.

D It is said that renting property is throwing money away, but so much of what one pays monthly on a mortgage goes on interest anyway that many people find it better to rent rather than buy.

E Magazines that show images of men and women who seem perfect are largely to blame for our discontent and for the increase in eating disorders among young people.

14 (Q27) Long-term unemployment is a big problem for the UK, both for the government and for the individual. The solution is unlikely to be one the government wishes to consider: invest money in improving the skills of job centre staff. Some people argue that providing welfare benefits makes unemployed people less motivated to find work. Other people, mostly outside the government, think that not enough is done to provide the help needed to get people into work. Neither side is right. Unemployed people are all different: some really want to work and would do so if they had help; others are content to live on benefits. We have to steer away from one-size-fits-all solutions and tailor the approach to the individual. But this needs much higher levels of skilled staff than job centres currently have.

Which one of the following best expresses the main conclusion of the above argument?

A Long-term unemployment is one of the biggest problems facing the UK.

B Unemployed people vary in their motivation to work.

C One-size-fits-all solutions tend to be cheaper than tailored approaches.

D The way to reduce unemployment is to spend on skilled staff in job centres.

E Welfare benefits provide a disincentive to work.

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15 (Q28) A Prime Minister has a difficult judgement to make when deciding whether to sack one of their ministers or not. Faced, for example, with a minister involved in some kind of scandal, the Prime Minister might feel they should sack them to show they stand up for integrity and high moral standards, or, on the other hand, allow them to remain in post for other reasons such as loyalty to a colleague or a belief that they are, on balance, doing a good job. Sacking ministers shows that the Prime Minister is prepared to live by principles, even if by so doing they lose valued colleagues. The electorate will judge the Prime Minister to have acted with integrity: that is an invaluable perception for anyone wishing to remain in power.

Which one of the following can be drawn as a conclusion from the above passage?

A It is in the Prime Minister's electoral interests to err on the side of sacking.

B Restoring public trust at a time when the reputation of politicians is low is a priority.

C Ministers are often sacked for a relatively minor wrongdoing when this is not in the interests of the country.

D Ministers involved in scandals should always be sacked.

E Politicians seek to stay in power at all costs.

16 (Q29) In a survey done by a school librarian during one year, borrowing of books in the library declined by 20%. Amongst books borrowed, rates of late return or loss of books also increased by 10%. On the other hand, student use of computers in the library increased by 25%. This finding was reinforced by frequent complaints from students that there were no computers available when they needed to use them. The librarian concluded that the best response to these findings was to cut the number of books and purchase more computers. 20% of books were sold off or given away, the space given over to additional computer tables, and the library's entire available budget given over to purchasing new computers.

Which one of the following is an underlying assumption of the librarian's reasoning?

A The library should cater for the students' preferences rather than trying to change them.

B A decline in the borrowing of books indicates a decline in reading.

C Students were unjustified in complaining about the lack of computers.

D Students' educational achievement is improved by using computers.

E Library use will necessarily increase if more computers are provided.

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17 (Q33) The current advice from the NHS in the UK is to eat five portions of fruit and vegetables a day. However, a recent study suggested that at least seven portions are needed to maximise health. Given that less than a third of adults in the UK, and even fewer children, currently meet the five-a-day target, there is little to be gained from changing the NHS advice to a higher number. A higher target might even be counter-productive, as evidence shows that a change in diet is best sustained when the change is made slowly and incrementally.

Which one of the following best expresses the main conclusion of the above argument?

A Eating seven portions of fruit and vegetables a day is needed to stay healthy.

B At least two thirds of the UK adult population ignore current guidelines.

C Current guidance on fruit and vegetable intake should be maintained.

D Setting high targets for a change in diet is unrealistic.

E Current advice on fruit and vegetable intake has not taken account of recent research.

18 (Q34) Welfare benefits create a culture of dependency and an unproductive workforce. There are people who stay on welfare benefits for years and never look for employment. Two years ago the government introduced tougher restrictions on the eligibility to receive benefits and the number of recipients has now fallen by 20%. The government should therefore toughen these restrictions even more to further reduce the number of welfare claimants.

Which one of the following identifies the flaw in the above argument?

A It rests on the false assumption that people are happy to stay on benefits and not look for work.

B It gives the impression that the benefits are undeserved.

C It ignores the possibility of other causes for the fall in the number of welfare recipients.

D It equates the recipients of benefits with an unproductive workforce.

E It implies that welfare recipients are in this situation due to their own fault.

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19 (Q35) There seems to be universal agreement on Shakespeare's greatness, yet many of his plays lack any significant development of plot or character. An exceptional skill with language is evident in all his works and his running theme concerning the relationship between appearances and reality has appealed to audiences across times and cultures. But is this enough to confer greatness? More likely this status derives from a small number of his plays, the four great tragedies, which succeed in dramatising reflection on the depths of the human condition. It is this which touches the hearts and minds of his audience.

Which one of the following best expresses the main conclusion of the above argument?

A Shakespeare's focus on the relationship between appearances and reality has appealed to audiences across times and cultures.

B There seems to be universal agreement on Shakespeare's greatness.

C Shakespeare succeeds in touching the hearts and minds of audiences.

D Shakespeare's greatness derives from a small number of his plays, the great tragedies.

E Limited plot and character development in many of his plays do not affect Shakespeare's reputation as a great playwright.

20 (Q39) Modern aeroplanes are for the most part 'flown' by autoflight computers. These computers can take over when the plane is just 30 metres off the ground, maintain whatever speed and height is tapped into the flight management system, and land the aircraft automatically. But when autoflight computers experience situations they haven't been programmed to handle – sudden structural damage to the aircraft, or extreme weather – they can throw back responsibility to the pilot, who may become confused over the level of control they have. The confusion is made worse by flight deck computers overloading pilots with a blizzard of alerts. This is when crashes are most likely to happen.

Which one of the following is a conclusion that can be drawn from the above passage?

A Developing autoflight computers further to allow pilotless planes is likely to be safer than the current arrangement.

B Automated systems can be refined to the extent that air crashes will not happen.

C The combination of computer and human control over an aircraft is unsafe in most situations.

D Autoflight computers can be controlled as easily from the ground as from inside the plane.

E Human error in entering data into autoflight computers will always pose a risk.

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21 (Q40) Children spend far too long in schools analysing poems when they should simply be learning to enjoy them. Thankfully, a new approach requires that, instead of focusing on analysing technical aspects of writing such as the writer's use of imagery or alliteration, children will be required simply to learn poems so that they can recite them by heart. This makes good sense. What is the use of learning how to analyse literature if you have no appreciation of its actual value? If they then become interested in it enough to study it at A level or at university, that can be when they learn to analyse in detail the author's craft.

Which one of the following is an underlying assumption of the above argument?

A Analysing the writer's craft could enhance the appreciation of the poem.

B Children are not currently required to learn poems off by heart.

C English will continue to be a subject available for study at A level or university.

D For something to be classed as poetry it must include either alliteration or imagery.

E Learning a poem off by heart will enable you to appreciate it more.

22 (Q41) The financial circumstances of many young people make it difficult for them to forego paid employment for an extended period in order to undertake unpaid internships or work experience placements. In many industries, it is unlikely that a young person will gain entry-level paid employment unless he or she has held one of these temporary unpaid positions. Therefore, the current system of unpaid internships creates an unfair advantage for individuals from more affluent backgrounds.

Which one of the following, if true, most weakens the above argument?

A Unpaid internships and work experience placements often provide young people with an important opportunity for gaining references.

B The highest proportion of unpaid internships and work experience placements are based in a few central locations, such as London.

C Unpaid internships and work experience placements come in various lengths of duration from one to two days up to a number of months.

D Some young people find themselves moving from one unpaid position to another without being able to land a paid job.

E Some schools and other organisations have programmes in place to help match young people with internships or work experience placements.

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23 (Q45) Charities address the negative effects of market economies, which apportion goods to people based on their ability to pay as opposed to their needs. The work of charities conceals the true impact of the market system and, worse, leaves the market in place to produce further negative outcomes. Charities therefore effectively perpetuate the problems the market system creates. Since it is immoral to support a practice that perpetuates the very problems it is supposed to resolve, giving to charity cannot be morally justified. After all, if the effects of a system are morally wrong, then it is immoral to sustain that system.

Which one of the following best expresses the main conclusion of the above argument?

A Charity does not address the cause of the problem.

B Charitable giving is necessary because of the market system.

C Charities perpetuate the negative effects of market economies.

D Giving to charity is immoral.

E Charities conceal the negative effects of the operation of the market.

24 (Q46) You can only grasp the true meaning of Pushkin's poetry if you can read it in its original Russian form. Your doctoral thesis on Pushkin's work shows acute insight so I can tell you have a mastery of the Russian language.

Which one of the following most closely parallels the reasoning used in the above argument?

A Only when there is a clear sky will you be able to practice some astronomy. Tonight is forecast to be cloudless so you will be able to do some stargazing.

B You have to place your dustbin on the street outside before 8 a.m. today for the refuse collectors to deal with it. Since you put yours in the correct place at 7 a.m. your dustbin will be emptied.

C You have to score at the 98th percentile or higher in a standardised IQ test to become a member of Mensa. As you are not a member of Mensa it is clear that your IQ falls outside the top 2%.

D Only towns that have a bypass to divert their traffic are able to create a pedestrian-only high street for local shoppers. I see your town has the benefit of traffic-free shopping, so the bypass must now be open.

E You need to have 45 hours in the air before you can take a pilot's licence test. You have only flown 18 hours so you will not be able to take the test.

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25 (Q47) It has emerged that prisoners have helped to maintain one of Britain's busiest railway lines. Inmates from an open prison have worked night-shifts on the main line from London to Glasgow. This is the same line where a train left the tracks earlier this year, killing one person and injuring several others. It is all very well to have offenders being rehabilitated through work, but what appears to be happening here is that rail contractors are cynically using prisoners as cheap labour. This is unacceptable, not just for safety reasons – important as they are – but because ultimately it is an infringement of workers' rights. If these prisoners are being paid less, or treated differently from regular workers, the practice must stop once and for all.

Which one of the following expresses the general principle that underlies the above argument?

A Labour is labour and should have the same value whoever is performing it.

B Public safety issues must always be given priority over economic advantages.

C Rehabilitation should be for the prisoner's benefit, not the employer's.

D Prisoners who are given work should not take jobs away from other workers.

E Maintenance of public services should be in the hands of skilled professionals only.

END OF TEST

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